surface. Authorization became something to model and reason about, not just something to code.

Product managers shifted from treating access control as a constraint to recognizing it as part of the product. As the decision surface expanded, decisions about delegation, collaboration boundaries, and contextual behavior were considered earlier in the design process. Policy flexibility became a tool for enabling new capabilities rather than an obstacle to delivering them.

Within the identity and security teams, there was a shift from review and enforcement toward stewardship. Their governance efforts increasingly focused on signal quality, policy lifecycle, and decision transparency. Instead of trying to prevent every risky action through manual processes like approvals and reviews, these teams focused on managing authorization pressure through infrastructure. Within those boundaries, actions could proceed without additional friction. This enabled the organization to move faster while ensuring that decisions remained controlled, observable, and consistent.

These shifts enabled new organizational capabilities. ACME could expand its decision surface—supporting more complex collaboration, delegation, and automation—without losing control. Partner onboarding accelerated as delegation models became easier to understand and implement. Automation expanded because its behavior could be constrained predictably. When decisions were challenged, the company could explain not only what happened, but why. *Authorization had not become simpler. But it had become deliberate.*

19.5 Where most organizations are today

Most organizations are still in the early stages of their journey toward strategic authorization. Authorization decisions are often embedded inside individual systems, shaped by the immediate needs of product teams and the limitations of current platforms. Role models evolve over time as new use cases arise. Contextual signals are added selectively to address specific risks. Governance practices develop unevenly across domains. These approaches